

HORTICULTURE AND CROP PRODUCTION

TOPIC 1: Introduction to Crop Production

Crop production is the growing of plants for food, income and industrial use. It is important to the national economy for food security, employment, export earnings and raw materials for industries.

TOPIC 2: Farm Tools and Safety Measures

Common tools: hoe, cutlass, rake, spade, watering can, wheelbarrow, measuring tape. Maintain tools by cleaning, sharpening and storing properly. Safety: use tools correctly, wear protective clothing, keep first-aid materials available, avoid working alone with dangerous tools.

TOPIC 3: Farmland Preparation Practices

Stages: clearing (remove vegetation), ploughing (turn soil), harrowing (break clods), ridging/bedding (for certain crops). Good preparation improves aeration, drainage and root growth. Farm layout and demarcation help organise plots.

TOPIC 4: Soil and Its Properties

Soil is the upper layer of the earth that supports plant growth. Types: sandy, clayey, loamy. Importance: provides anchorage, water, air and nutrients. Physical properties: colour, texture (particle size), structure (arrangement of particles). Soil quality strongly affects crop yield.

TOPIC 5: Soil Texture and Structure

Texture (sand, silt, clay proportions) affects water holding and workability. Structure affects root penetration and drainage. Simple tests (feel method) help identify texture. Soil management: organic manure, mulching, avoiding compaction.

TOPIC 6: Site Selection and Crop Types

Factors for site selection: topography, soil type, water availability, sunlight, access. Crops classified by lifespan: annual, biennial, perennial. Types: arable (field crops), horticultural (vegetables, fruits, ornamentals), plantation (tree crops).

TOPIC 7: Crop Classification

Food crops (for eating), cash crops (for sale), industrial crops (for factories). Annual crops complete life cycle in one season; biennials in two; perennials live for many years. Classification helps in planning and marketing.

Summary

Horticulture and crop production involve land preparation, soil knowledge, site selection and crop classification. Good tools, safety and soil management are the foundation of successful crop farming.